in order to show how political language had been used to justify a reckless incidence of murder. There was no other word for it, and although we knew it would be controversial, the decision to call the video ‘Collateral Murder’ was simply loyal to the evidence.

The storm that blew up about that title was depressing and surprising, even given what I knew about the attitude of much of the Western media to the official US government line. So puffed up are they with a sense of their own importance that, on seeing the video, the first debate they wanted to have was about our title, not about the contents. Much of the press think pairing the truth with the official lie is ‘balance’, and mistake a solemn delivery to camera for serious engagement with moral imperatives. Paul Krugman once joked that if one party declared that the earth was flat, the headlines would read ‘Views Differ on Shape of Planet’. Our ‘edited’ version showed the first eleven minutes completely unedited, to set the scene. We put it up on the website collateralmurder.net *right next to* the full 40-minute version. Dear CNN, what exactly is your problem? Perhaps we should have called it ‘Collateral Cover Up’ and had done with it.

I must have seen the video hundreds of times, but, on each occasion, my blood ran cold when I saw those children coming under attack. Unchecked power is such an evil thing and I came to feel a large moral responsibility for exposing the bastards who did this. In a sense, the bastards were the US military, but also those elements of the media who had seen fit to join them in covering the thing up. The young men in the helicopter may be victims, too; victims of a brutal military culture gone out of control, and you can hear the eagerness in their voices to make a ‘kill’. It was certainly the case that one of the soon-to-be victims was carrying an RPG (a rocket-propelled grenade), but in their eagerness to build a threatening picture the forces in the helicopter mistook the Reuters photographer’s camera for a second one. The rush to judgement is obscene, especially if you listen to the frantic, beseeching voice of the gunman, failing to understand why there would be any reason to show caution in such a situation. ‘Come on, buddy, all you gotta do is pick up a weapon’ one of them says of a guy on the ground. ‘Gimme something.’ And so we go from a situation of low enemy threat to a massacre in a matter of minutes. The video gives a massive insight into the merciless need for ‘contact’ that a war fosters in its participants. It looks and sounds like a computer game, and that’s because the morality of the